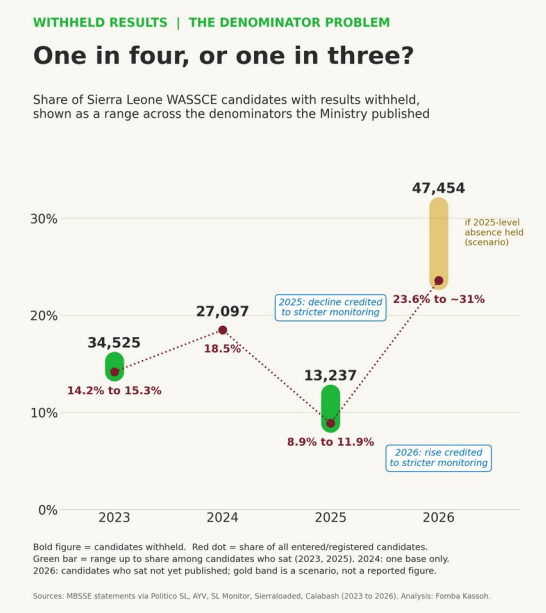
SIERRA LEONE | WITHHELD WASSCE AND NPSE RESULTS

47,454 Results Withheld: Cheating, Catching, or Paperwork?

A data review of every published figure from 2018 to 2026: what the numbers show, what they hide, and what families are owed



The same 2026 count is one in four or nearly one in three, depending on which denominator is used.

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Summary

On 27 October 2026 the Ministry of Basic and Senior Secondary Education announced that the results of 47,454 WASSCE candidates had been withheld over suspected examination malpractice. It is the largest number in the recent Sierra Leone record, and it lands on families in the middle of university admissions season.

This paper asks what that number can and cannot tell us. It rebuilds the public record from Ministry statements, WAEC releases and the

one detailed official case report available, for 2020, and it puts every figure through the same arithmetic checks. Four findings stand out.

First, "withheld" is not one thing. The same word on a results portal covers at least six situations: suspected candidate malpractice, insider malpractice by officials, missing continuous assessment scores, registration and eligibility defects, unpaid fees, and cases still being processed. Only the first two involve anyone's alleged misconduct,

and only the first involves the candidate's.

Second, the size of the problem depends on the denominator. The 2026 figure is 23.6 percent of registered candidates. Among candidates who actually sat, which has not been published, it could be close to one in three. Across 2023 to 2026, the Ministry has used entries, registrations, results lists and candidates sitting as the base in different years.

Third, the public explanation cannot be tested. In 2025 a fall in withheld results was credited to stricter monitoring. In 2026 a rise was explained the same way. An explanation that fits movement in both directions does not tell the public which is happening: more cheating, or more catching.

Fourth, Sierra Leone publishes the count but not the outcome. The 2020 WAEC report showed what happens after a hold: no reported candidate was cleared, and 73 percent of cases ended with a subject

result cancelled rather than the whole result. No equivalent outcome report has been found for any year since.

None of this argues that malpractice is imaginary or that enforcement should ease. It argues that a system which withholds tens of thousands of results a year owes candidates, parents and the public a clearer account of why, and of what happened next. The paper closes with eight practical recommendations, several of which build on commitments the government has already made.

Why this matters now

Sierra Leone's examination system has grown faster than almost any in the region. The Ministry reported that WASSCE candidature rose by 479 percent between 2018 and 2022, reaching 186,695 candidates with results. School enrolment overall rose from about 2.0 million in 2018 to more than 3.4 million by 2024 under the Free Quality School Education programme. That expansion is a real achievement. It also means the machinery that registers, supervises,

marks and investigates has had to scale at the same pace.

For 2026 the Ministry reported 201,124 candidates registered from 1,043 schools, results for 200,756 candidates from 1,038 schools, 368 candidates from five private schools excluded for unpaid fees, and 47,454 candidates (26,735 female and 20,719 male) with their entire results withheld. The Ministry said WAEC may release some or all of these after investigation, and cancel the rest.

Each of those 47,454 is a young person whose next step, a university place, a college course, a job application, now waits on a committee. Some will be found to have cheated. Some will not. How quickly and how transparently that distinction is made is the subject of this paper.

One word, six meanings



Figure 1. Six situations that end in the same word. Colour indicates where responsibility lies.

Under WAEC's rules, a withheld result is an interim status pending investigation, and a cancelled result is the final sanction once a committee finds a candidate culpable. That distinction is clear. What is less clear in public reporting is that results can also be held for reasons that have nothing to do with a candidate's conduct.

The 2026 primary examination shows why this matters. When 1,927 NPSE results were set aside in August, the headline read like a cheating scandal among children. The Minister later

explained that the main cause was schools failing to submit continuous assessment records, which make up part of each pupil's score. Insider cases matter too: the Anti-Corruption Commission has indicted WAEC's chief and assistant chief examiners over an alleged 2024 script, and separately a WAEC computer programmer over alleged grade changes in 2020. These are allegations before the courts, not findings, but they show that integrity failures are not confined to candidates.

Sierra Leone's 2026 release did separate fee holds from malpractice holds, which is good practice. It did not report technical or processing cases separately, as Nigeria does, nor report any subject-level holds, as Ghana does.

How big is the problem?

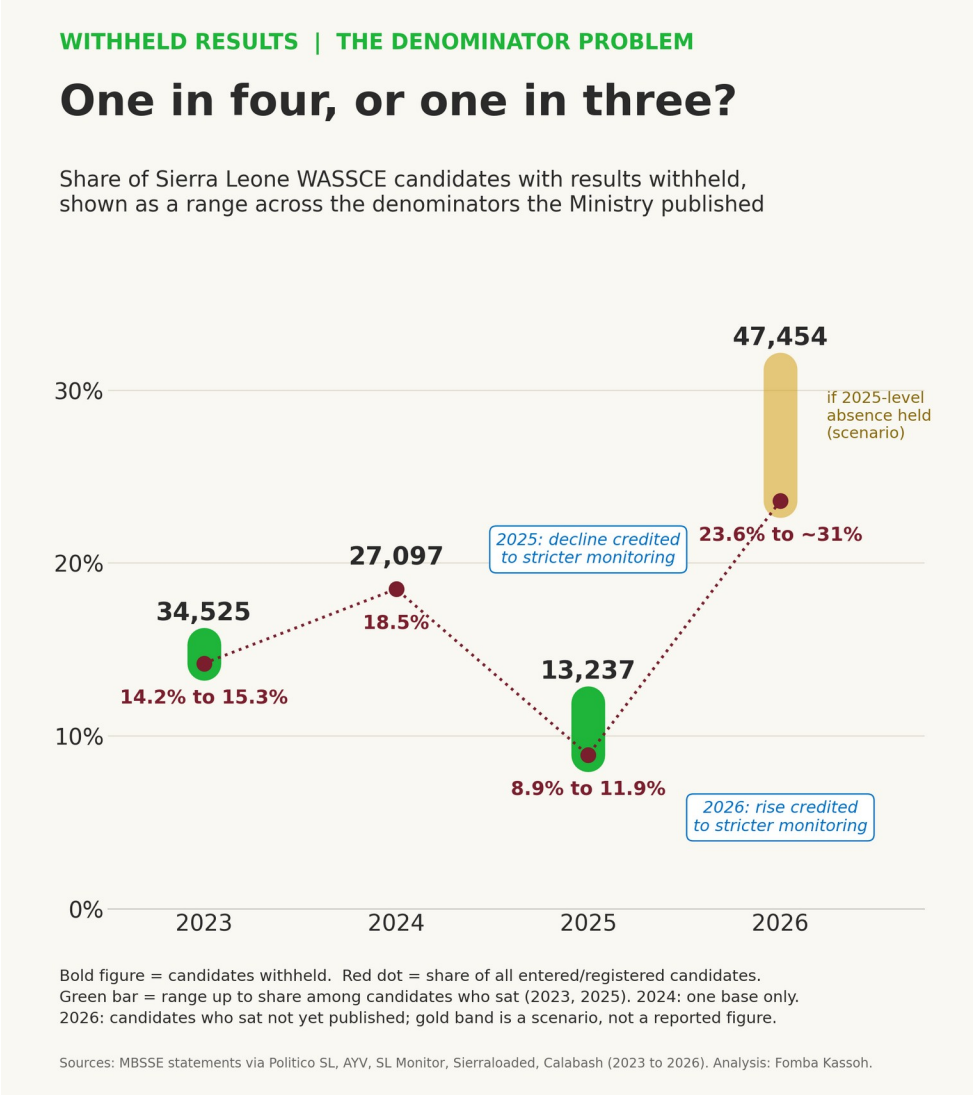


Figure 2. Withheld results as a share of candidates, 2023 to 2026, shown as a range across the published denominators.

The headline counts are well documented: 34,525 withheld in 2023, 27,097 in 2024, 13,237 in 2025 and 47,454 in 2026. The rates are not. Each year's announcement used a different base, and the choice changes the answer.

In 2023 the Ministry reported 243,202 entries, 230,973 candidates on the results list, and 191,077 who sat at least one subject and received results. The withholding rate is 14.2 percent of entries but 15.3 percent of candidates who sat. In 2025 the gap is wider: 8.9 percent of the 148,362 registered in

June, but 11.9 percent of those who sat, because 35,020 candidates on the list were absent from every paper.

For 2026 only the registration figure is public, so 23.6 percent is the lowest defensible rate. If absenteeism matched 2023 levels, the rate among candidates who sat would be about 24 percent. If it matched 2025 levels, it would be about 31 percent. Neither is a reported figure; both show why the number of candidates who sat should be published alongside the number withheld.

A discrepancy resolved. The 2023 announcement cited both 34,525 withheld and 33,238 candidates without results, and secondary accounts have treated these as conflicting. They are not. The results list of 230,973, minus the 191,077 with results, minus the 6,658 absent from all subjects, leaves exactly 33,238. That is the withheld group on the list. The headline 34,525 also includes 1,287 withheld candidates outside it. Applying the same arithmetic to 2025 leaves 2,089 withheld candidates outside the list

whom no published figure explains. Appendix A lists every reconciliation check.

Cheating, or catching?

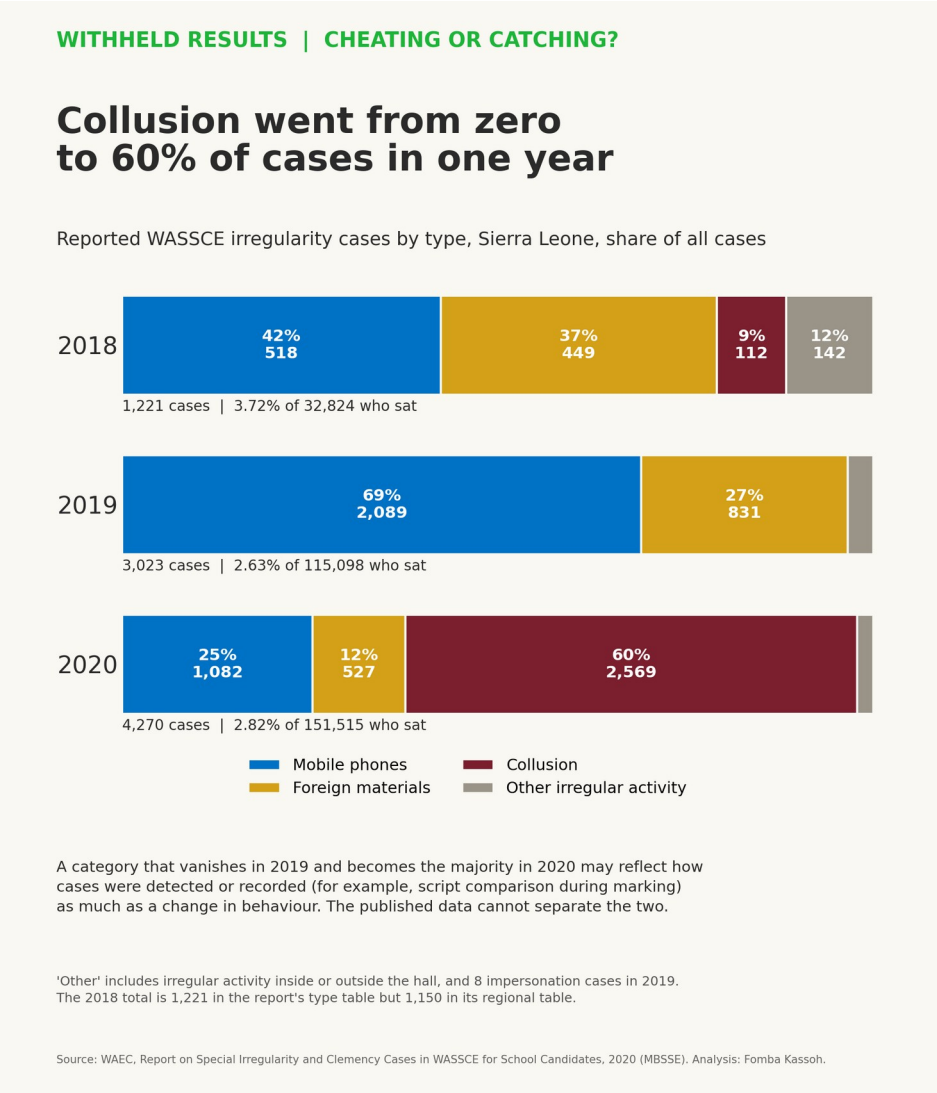


Figure 3. Reported WASSCE irregularity cases by type, 2018 to 2020. Source: WAEC report on special irregularity and clemency cases, 2020.

Any count of withheld results mixes two things: how much malpractice occurs, and how much of it is detected. Tighter supervision, better script comparison during marking, or broader rules can all raise the count with no change in behaviour. A count can also fall because detection weakened.

The public explanation has not helped separate the two. When the 2025 figure fell, the Ministry credited stricter monitoring for curbing cheating. When the 2026 figure rose, it said stricter monitoring could mean

more cases were being detected, while adding, fairly, that the scale of the increase required investigation. Both statements may be true in their own year. Together they show that monitoring alone cannot explain the movement in either direction.

The 2020 WAEC report offers the clearest historical evidence that detection matters. It breaks reported cases down by type for 2018, 2019 and 2020.

Collusion accounted for 112 cases in 2018, none in 2019, and 2,569 in

2020, 60 percent of the total. Mobile phone cases moved the other way, from 2,089 to 1,082. The report notes that cases were both reported during the examination and detected during marking. A category that disappears and then becomes the majority in a single year may reflect how cases were found or recorded as much as how candidates behaved. The published data cannot separate the two, which is exactly the point: without a published breakdown of how each case was detected, neither can anyone else.

The Ministry has promised to publish a breakdown of the 13 reasons for the 2026 holds, distinguishing collusion within a room from the use of social media or artificial intelligence to share answers across centres. That release will be the most useful single dataset for answering this question, and it should be repeated every year.

What happens after a hold

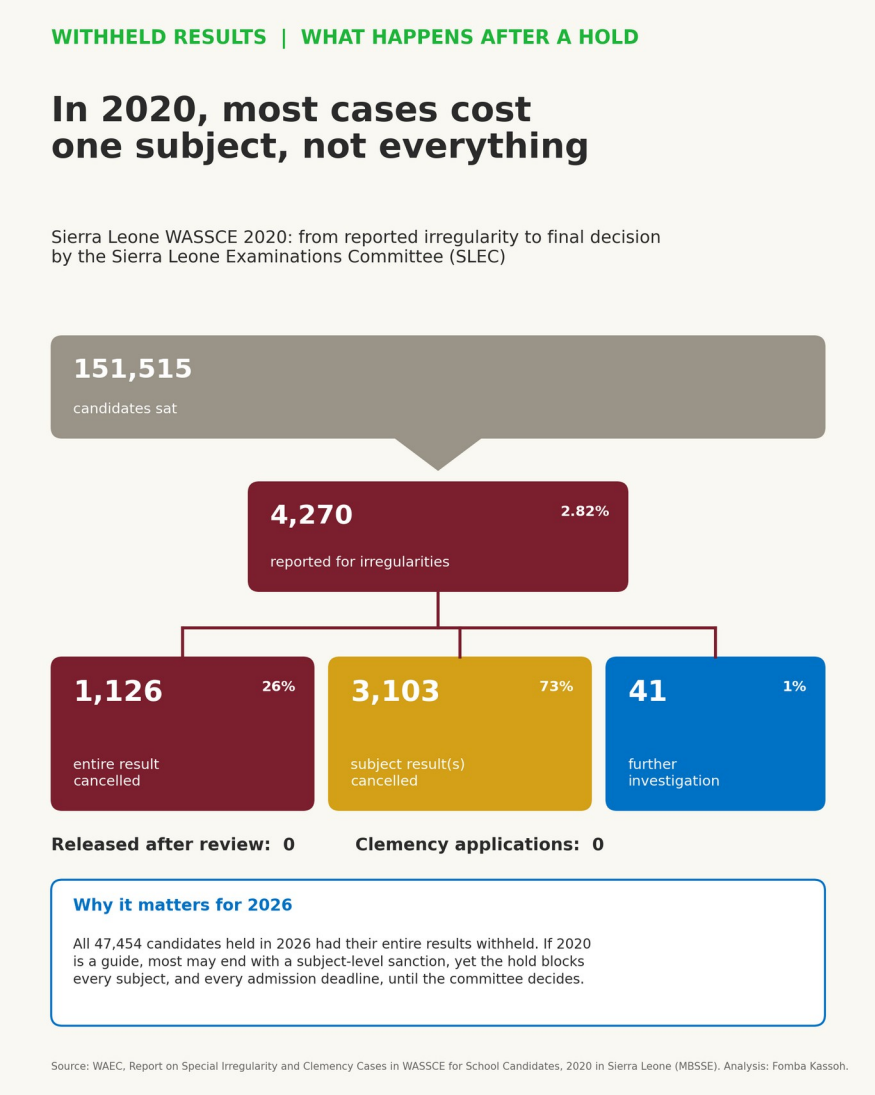


Figure 4. From reported irregularity to final decision, WASSCE 2020.

A withheld result is supposed to be temporary. The only year for which the full outcome is public is 2020.

Of 151,515 candidates who sat in 2020, 4,270 (2.82 percent) were reported for irregularities. The Sierra Leone Examinations Committee cancelled the entire results of 1,126, cancelled one or more subject results for 3,103, and referred 41 for further investigation. Those three numbers add up to 4,270. No reported candidate was cleared, and no candidate applied for clemency.

Two things follow. First, in 2020 a report almost always ended in a sanction, which suggests either that reporting was reliable or that the review process rarely overturned it; the public record cannot say which. Second, nearly three in four cases ended with a subject-level penalty, not loss of the whole result. All 47,454 holds announced in 2026 cover entire results. If 2020 is any guide, many may end in a subject-level sanction, yet in the meantime the hold blocks every subject, and every admission deadline, until the committee decides.

Not every hold is about the pupil

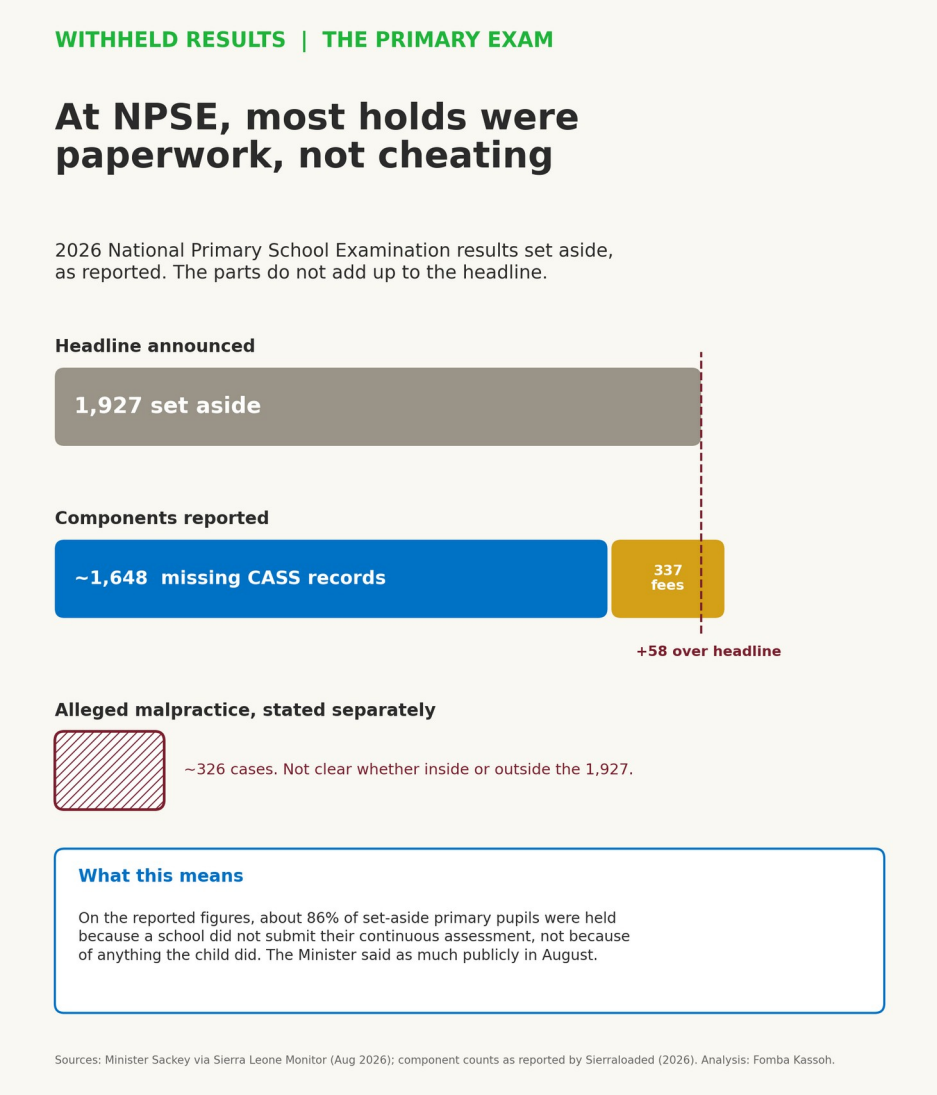


Figure 5. NPSE 2026 results set aside, as reported.

At the primary level the administrative share is clearest. The components reported for the 2026 NPSE, about 1,648 results held over missing continuous assessment records and 337 over unpaid fees, add up to 1,985, which is 58 more than the 1,927 headline. Around 326 alleged malpractice cases were mentioned separately, and it is not clear whether they fall inside or outside the 1,927. On the reported figures, roughly 86 percent of set-aside primary pupils were held because a school did not submit their assessment.

At secondary level, fee holds affected more than 3,500 candidates in 2025 and 368 in 2026. These are separate from malpractice and the Ministry reported them separately. The principle is the same in each case: where an adult or an institution failed, the pupil should not carry the cost for longer than it takes to verify the record.

The register question



Figure 6. WASSCE 2026 candidate counts, February to October.

There is a further possibility the public data can raise but not answer: that

part of the withholding problem is a registration problem.

In February 2026 the Minister said schools had uploaded 219,000 names to the Batch Registration System, including 74,000 the Ministry had not verified, which he described as an attempt to bypass BECE checks. After a cleanup with the teachers' union and the placement service, 19,000 more were cleared and 55,000 remained unmatched. That implies about 164,000 cleared; the Minister also cited a figure of 140,000. In October the register stood at 201,124,

roughly 37,000 above the implied cleared total.

The 2025 record points the same way. Of 143,985 candidates on the results list, 35,020, about one in four, were absent from every paper. In 2023 the equivalent figure was 6,658, under 3 percent. Names that are registered but never sit are a familiar signal of register inflation.

This paper does not claim that withheld candidates and late or unverified registrations are the same people. It asks the question the

Ministry is best placed to answer: how many of the 47,454 came from names that were unmatched in February? A school-level match would show whether Sierra Leone has one problem or two. The government's planned unique learner identification system, intended to detect candidates registered in more than one school, is the right tool, and its first results should be published.

Sierra Leone in the region

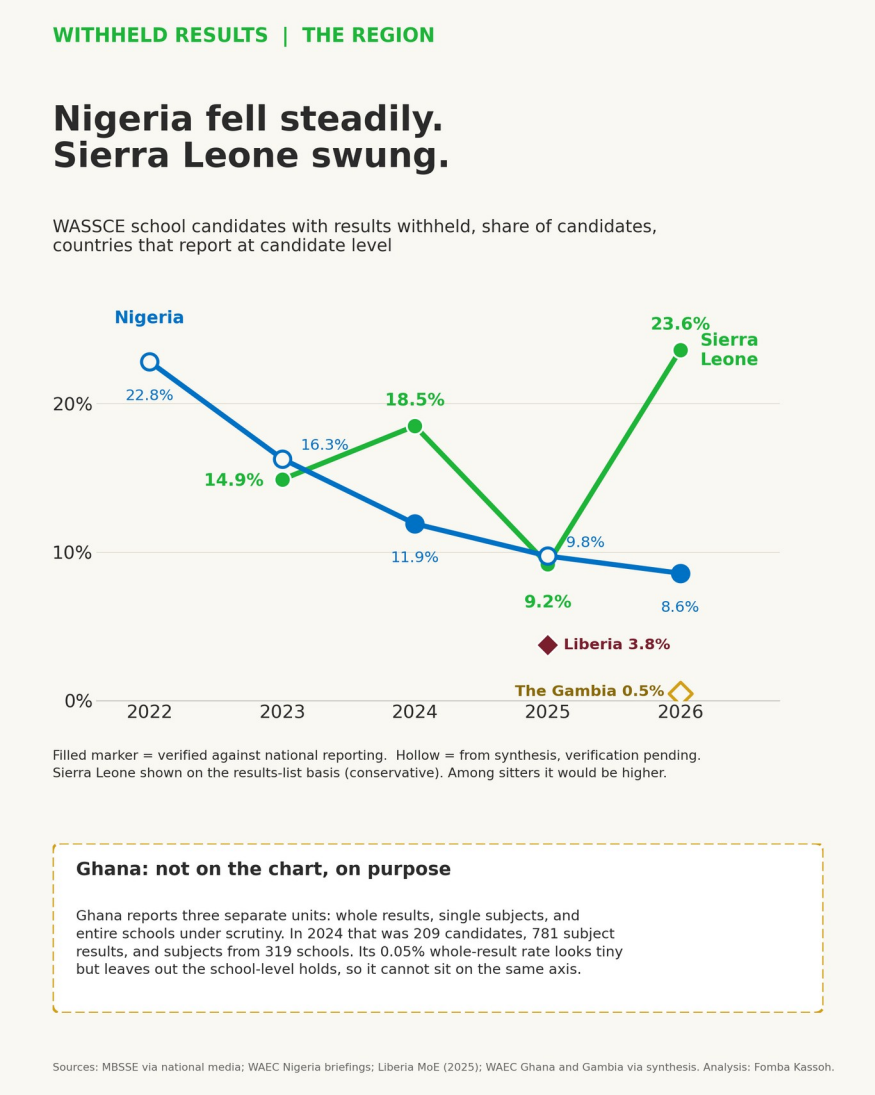


Figure 7. WASSCE withholding rates in countries that report at candidate level. Hollow markers are pending verification.

Sierra Leone is not uniquely affected. Nigeria withheld 22.8 percent of results in 2022 and has fallen every year since, to 8.6 percent in 2026, when 167,486 of 1,950,726 candidates were withheld. Liberia withheld 1,944 of 51,719 in 2025, or 3.8 percent. The Gambia reported about 0.5 percent in 2026. What distinguishes Sierra Leone is not the level but the volatility: 14.9, 18.5, 9.2 and 23.6 percent on the results-list basis over four years.

Ghana is left off the chart on purpose. It reports whole-result holds, subject-

level holds and entire schools under scrutiny as separate figures, so its whole-result rate of a fraction of a percent leaves out most of the affected population. Comparing it with Sierra Leone's candidate count would flatter Ghana and mislead readers about Sierra Leone.

Nigeria's 2026 total includes centres in Benin, Côte d'Ivoire and Equatorial Guinea, a small effect on the rate. Nigeria's 2022, 2023 and 2025 figures, and The Gambia's, are taken from secondary sources and are

marked for verification before final publication.

What gets published

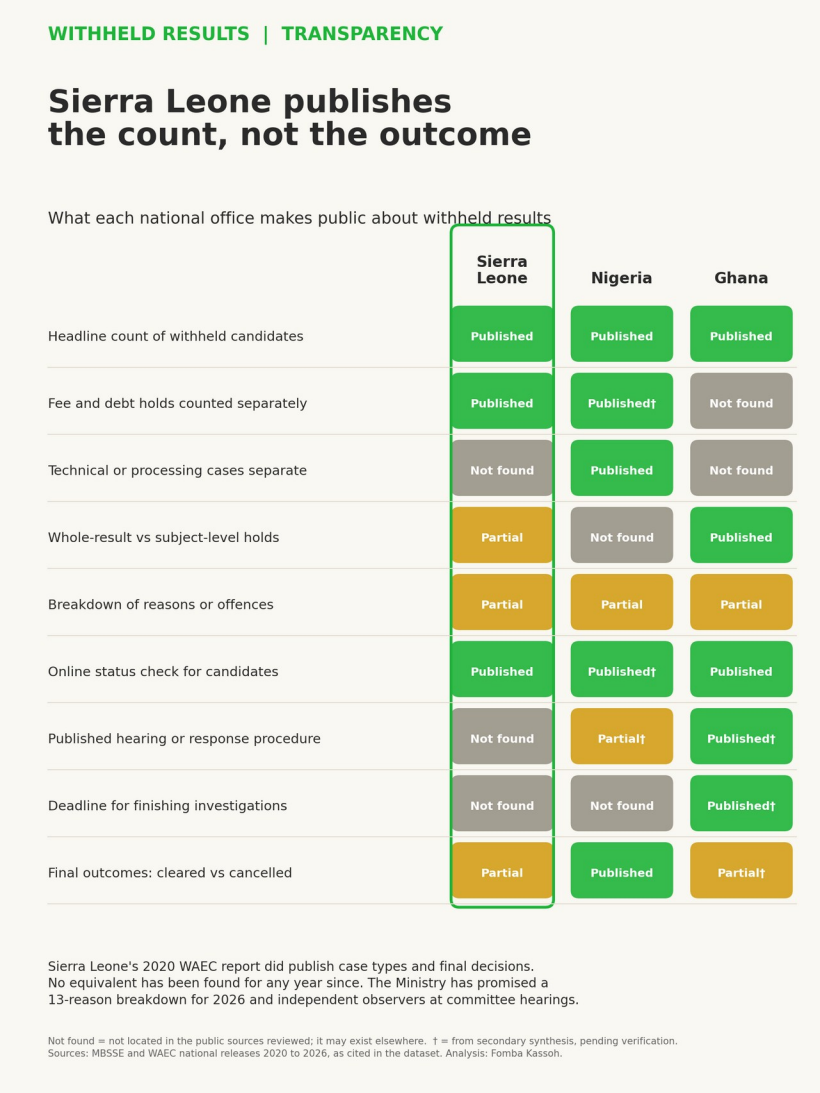


Figure 8. What each national office makes public about withheld results.

Sierra Leone does several things well.

It announces the headline count

promptly, separates fee holds, and lets candidates check their status online. Its 2020 WAEC report, published on the Ministry's website, set out case types, regional rates and final decisions in more detail than most countries publish.

What is missing is everything after the announcement. No public source reviewed for this paper gives Sierra Leone's investigation deadline, the procedure by which a candidate learns the allegation and responds, or the number of candidates cleared and cancelled in any year since 2020.

Ghana publishes subject-level holds and, according to secondary accounts still being verified, has described a fair-hearing process with a fixed investigation window. Nigeria reports technical and processing cases separately and announces the release of exonerated candidates' results through its national examinations committee.

The government's 2026 commitments move in the right direction: the Chief Education Officer working with the WAEC committee to speed decisions, three respected educationists

observing committee deliberations, referral of principals and proprietors involved in repeated malpractice to the Anti-Corruption Commission, recovery of funds paid for ineligible candidates, and a new WAEC bill in 2027. The recommendations below are designed to make those commitments measurable.

Recommendations

1. One table, six categories, every release

Every results announcement should include a single table separating suspected candidate malpractice, centre or school-level malpractice, missing continuous assessment, registration and eligibility defects, fee holds, and technical processing. The 2026 release already does part of this.

2. Publish outcomes, not just holds

At fixed points, for example 60 and 120 days after release, publish how many withheld candidates have been cleared, how many had subjects cancelled, how many lost their entire result, and how many remain pending. Publish the promised 13-reason breakdown every year, not only in 2026.

3. Hold only what the evidence touches

Where an allegation concerns one paper, hold that subject and release the rest, unless WAEC rules require a whole-result hold for that offence. The 2020 record suggests most cases end at subject level anyway.

4. A deadline, and a fast track for admissions

Set and publish a maximum investigation period, and give priority to candidates with university or college deadlines. A hold that outlasts

the admissions cycle becomes a penalty in itself, whatever the committee later decides.

5. Sanction adults for adult failures

When a school fails to submit assessment records, register candidates correctly, or remit fees it has collected, direct the sanction at the principal or proprietor and release the pupil's result as soon as the record can be verified. This matters most at NPSE, where the candidates are children in compulsory basic education.

6. Match the register to the holds

Publish a school-level reconciliation of names uploaded, names unmatched, candidates absent from all papers, and results withheld. Report the first findings of the unique learner identification system.

7. Write procedural rights into the 2027 WAEC bill

Alongside new offences, the bill should guarantee notice of the allegation, a chance to respond, a reasoned decision, a route to review, a time limit, and protection against

collective punishment where an individual cannot reasonably be linked to wrongdoing.

8. Release the data in machine-readable form

Publish each year's figures as a downloadable file with stable definitions, and update final dispositions as cases close. Most of the discrepancies listed in Appendix A would disappear if the underlying tables were public.

What this paper cannot tell you

It cannot say how much malpractice actually occurs, because detection and incidence cannot be separated in the public data. It cannot say how many 2026 candidates will be cleared. It cannot say whether withheld candidates overlap with late or unverified registrations; it can only show why the question deserves an answer. Several regional figures rest on secondary sources and are marked as such. Where public figures conflict,

the conflict is shown rather than smoothed over.

A note on sources and method

Figures were compiled into a single dataset, one row per country, year, examination and measure, each tagged with its source and a reliability tier: official documents (tier 1), official statements reported by national media (tier 2), and secondary synthesis awaiting verification (tier 3). Rates were computed under every published denominator rather than one chosen base. The principal official source for 2018 to 2020 is WAEC's

Report on Special Irregularity and Clemency Cases in WASSCE for School Candidates, 2020 in Sierra Leone, published on the Ministry's website. Figures for 2023 to 2026 come from Ministry announcements as reported by Politico SL, AYV, Sierra Leone Monitor, Sierraloaded and The Calabash. Regional figures come from WAEC national offices and the Liberian Ministry of Education. The full dataset and workbook accompany this paper.

Appendix A. Reconciliation checks

Every published figure was checked against the others. Resolved items are explained; unresolved items are flagged for the Ministry.

Item	Check	Status
2023 WASSCE	34,525 withheld vs 33,238 "without results". List 230,973 minus 191,077 with results minus 6,658 absent = 33,238; 1,287 withheld are off the list.	Resolved: scope difference
2025 WASSCE	13,237 withheld (Ministry, 2026) vs 13,213 (other October 2025 reports).	Unresolved: 24
2025 WASSCE	Same method as 2023 leaves 2,089 withheld candidates outside the results list.	Unresolved
2026 WASSCE	201,124 registered minus 200,756 on list = 368, the five fee-held	Resolved

Item	Check	Status
	private schools.	
2026 WASSCE	201,124 described as "registered" by the Ministry and as "sat" by one outlet.	Definitional
2026 WASSCE	February cleared total: 140,000 cited; 164,000 implied by 219,000 uploaded minus 55,000 unmatched.	Unresolved
2026 NPSE	Components 1,648 + 337 = 1,985 vs 1,927 headline; ~326 malpractice cases stated separately.	Unresolved: +58
2018 WASSCE	WAEC 2020 report: 1,221 cases in type table, 1,150 in regional table.	Unresolved: 71

Appendix B. Withholding rates by denominator

Year	Withheld	Entries or registered	Results list	Among sitters
2023	34,525	14.2%	14.9%	15.3%
2024	27,097	18.5%	not published	not published
2025	13,237	8.9%	9.2%	11.9%
2026	47,454	23.6%	23.6%	24% to 31% (scenario)

2026 sitters have not been published. The scenario applies 2023 and 2025 absence rates to the 2026 results list.

Appendix C. Reported irregularities by region, 2018 to 2020

Source: WAEC report on special irregularity and clemency cases, 2020. Rates are reported cases as a share of candidates who sat in each region. Regional rates are shaped by school mix, urban concentration, supervision intensity and detection, and should not be read as a measure of any community's honesty or as a partisan indicator. They are included for completeness and so that each

region's education officers can track their own trend.

Region	Sat 2020	Reported 2020	Rate 2018	Rate 2019	Rate 2020
Western	68,680	1,364	3.85%	2.78%	1.99%
Southern	15,231	142	0.61%	0.40%	0.93%
Eastern	30,182	1,706	1.98%	3.06%	5.65%
Northern	37,306	1,058	4.95%	2.96%	2.84%
National	151,515	4,270	3.72%	2.63%	2.82%

About the author

Fomba Kassoh is a data scientist and adjunct lecturer in artificial intelligence and business analytics, and a railway service planning and operations professional. He holds

degrees in civil, water resources and transportation engineering and an M.S. in Data Science from CUNY. He partners with communities in Sierra Leone to build elementary schools and educate pupil teachers, farms oil palm in Kambia District, and serves as Secretary General of the SLPP North America, New York Chapter. This paper is an independent analysis; its findings apply the same scrutiny to government institutions as to any other.